internal balancing strategy vis-à-vis China. And in 2000, Vajpayee alluded to this, declaring that India and the US were “natural allies.”[1]

The Indian government subsequently had high hopes for the incoming Bush administration, which believed China was a strategic competitor. And as National Security Adviser Condoleezza Rice had indicated during the campaign, it saw India as part of the solution to its China problem. But any major US geopolitical adjustment in the Asia-Pacific and consequent deepening of the partnership with India was put on hold after the September 11 terrorist attacks. Nevertheless, the Bush administration’s lifting of sanctions paved the way for activities like the resumption of US-India naval exercises. Moreover, it led to the two countries signing the Next Steps in Strategic Partnership agreement, which sought to expand cooperation with regard to civilian nuclear activities, civilian space programs, and high-technology trade, as well as to the dialogue on missile defense.

If there were doubts about whether the approach taken by a center-right government in India would survive its defeat, Manmohan Singh dispelled them. His Congress Party–led coalition, despite needing the support of communist parties that vehemently opposed a partnership with the US, picked up where its predecessor had left off. When the Bush administration, spurred in no small part by its longer-term concern about China, proposed negotiations toward a US-India civil nuclear deal, the Singh government agreed. The deal was portrayed in India as stemming from a desire to improve energy security or legitimize India’s nuclear program. However, as Indian policymakers have subsequently acknowledged, the agreement was also about overcoming a legacy obstacle to pave the way for a strategic relationship with the US in the face of a rising China. And they pursued this deal knowing that there would be pushback not just from domestic constituencies but potentially from Beijing and Moscow as well.

Over the course of two terms in office, as a rising China’s behavior caused greater concern, the Singh government worked with the Bush and then the Obama administrations to deepen defense and security relations. It signed a Defense Framework Agreement, paving the way for dialogues, exercises, and talks on technology transfer. The Singh government also initiated the first major Indian purchases of US defense equipment after decades of buying largely Soviet or Russian equipment. Moreover, despite its historical caution about joining coalitions that could be seen as directed